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INVESTMENT 01/11

COLLEGE SPORTS CAPITAL

WHY PRIVATE EQUITY IS STILL WAITING ON COLLEGE SPORTS

Per a panel at the University of Michigan Sport Business Conference

SWIPE →

HOW CAPITAL GETS IN

THE DEAL SHAPES ON THE TABLE

1 A STAKE IN A NEW COMPANY

Utah moved commercial operations into Crimson Brand Partners. The university holds a majority stake and Otro Capital a minority stake.

2 A CONFERENCE PARTNERSHIP

The Big 12 approved a five-year business partnership with RedBird Capital Partners.

3 PRIVATE CREDIT

Structured as loans, with investors providing financing, collecting interest, and getting repaid. Experts see it as the easier path.

THE PANEL

WHO SPOKE AT MICHIGAN

SP

SAM PORTER

Chief strategy officer
Apollo Sports Capital

TP

TIM PERNETTI

Commissioner
American Conference

MK

MAGDALENA KALA

Co-founder and COO
Smash Sports

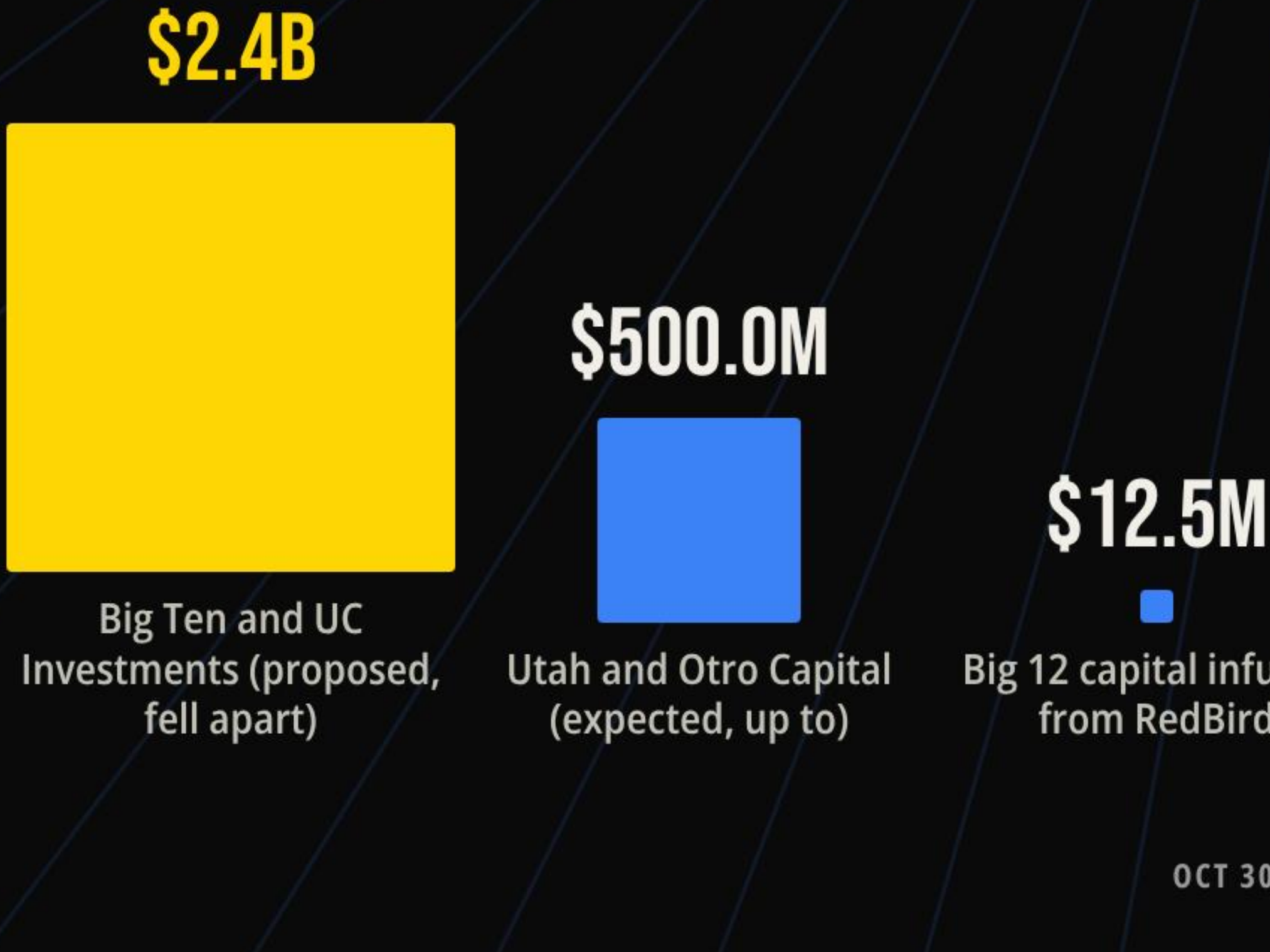
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DEAL SIZES

THE COLLEGE CAPITAL DEALS, BY ANNOUNCED SIZE

USD



OCT 30, 2026

THE BIG TEN VOTE

THE DEAL THAT FELL APART

16

of the 18 Big Ten teams were reportedly in favor

18

Big Ten teams

The two holdouts were Michigan and USC. UC Investments would not sign without them.

OCT 30, 2026

THE BIG 12 MODEL

WHAT THE BIG 12 DEAL PROVIDES

$12.5M

at least, to the conference

$30M

in credit, optional, up to, per school

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THE HESITATION

WHAT INVESTORS SAY IS IN THE WAY

1 NO RULEBOOK

With professional leagues, "you know who's making the rules," Porter said. In college "there's just so much unknown."

2 REALIGNMENT AND LAWSUITS

Porter pointed to conference realignment and the legal fights that have followed.

3 A NOT-FOR-PROFIT UMBRELLA

Pernetti said college sports has historically not had investors who demand a return on investment.

4 ATHLETE EMPLOYMENT

Whether athletes should be classified as employees remains unsettled.

HOW WE GOT HERE

COLLEGE SPORTS AND PRIVATE CAPITAL

NOV 21, 2025

SBJ reports the Big Ten is working on a $2.4 billion private capital deal with UC Investments

APR 29, 2026

The Athletic reports the Big 12 has closed a private capital deal through a RedBird and Weatherford Capital venture

JUN 12, 2026

Utah finalizes its deal with Otro Capital

OCT 29, 2026

Michigan Sport Business Conference panel on why private equity is hesitant

WHAT COULD CHANGE IT

THE PROTECT COLLEGE SPORTS ACT

1 WHERE IT STANDS

Approved in the Senate. It awaits a vote in the House. Its passing is not guaranteed.

2 WHAT IT WOULD DO

Double the revenue-sharing cap, limit conference realignment, and allow schools to pool and sell media rights together.

3 WHAT INVESTORS ASKED FOR

Porter said "legislation that makes clear how rights will be handled."

“

College sports has become a multibillion-dollar industry built on the backs of college athletes who are in the spotlight all the time.

TIM PERNETTI

Commissioner, American Conference

OCT 30, 2026

SOURCES

SOURCES

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The Salt Lake Tribune: Utah Utes private-equity deal with Otro Capital is finalized
sltrib.com

Front Office Sports: Big 12 Presidents Approve Deal With RedBird Capital
frontofficesports.com

The Athletic: Big 12 reaches private capital deal
nytimes.com

Sports Business Journal: Why USC, Michigan are holding up Big Ten private equity deal
sportsbusinessjournal.com

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